



GOVERNMENT OF THE PEOPLE, BY THE PEOPLE, FOR THE PEOPLE, SHALL NOT PERISH FROM THE EARTH

THE GETTYSBURG ADDRESS (1863)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The American Civil War

BEFORE

1820 An attempt is made, in the Missouri Compromise statute, to restrict slavery in the new states to a line south of the Missouri border.

1854 The Kansas-Nebraska Act sparks violence in Kansas.

1857 The Dred Scott Decision rules that even in non-slave states enslaved people cannot be freed.

1861 The Confederate States are declared (February); in April, the Civil War begins.

1863 In July, the Confederates are defeated at Gettysburg and Vicksburg.

AFTER

1864 Lincoln is reelected.

1865 General Lee surrenders; Lincoln is assassinated.

On November 19, 1863, little more than halfway through the American Civil War, in Gettysburg, Pennsylvania, US President Abraham Lincoln gave what came to be known as the Gettysburg Address. In it, he characterized the Civil War as a struggle both for national unity and to guarantee equality for all people.

Lincoln was talking at the dedication of the Soldiers' National Cemetery, which commemorated the 7,058 soldiers killed at the Battle of Gettysburg, an encounter fought between July 1–3 the same year that had left 27,224 more wounded. Gettysburg had been the bloodiest battle of the American Civil War, as well as a turning point in which the outnumbered, outgunned, yet improbably successful Southern army led by Robert E. Lee, the Army of Northern Virginia, suffered its first major defeat.

The causes of the war

The American Civil War was not simply a war about slavery; it was a war about whether so divisive an issue could be allowed to break up the United States. The United States, as Lincoln said, was a nation “conceived in liberty and dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal,” yet its Southern states had a population of almost 4 million enslaved black people. Under the US constitution, they were legally owned property. For the abolitionists of the rapidly industrializing north—always a minority, but still exceedingly vocal—slavery was morally repugnant and an outrage against their Christian sensibilities.

However, slavery was not just the backbone of the agricultural prosperity of the Southern states; for slave-owning Southerners, it was a right. For them, “liberty” had an additional meaning: the liberty to possess enslaved people.

The disagreement underlined the question over States' Rights—the extent to which the rights of individual states